

Weeks 5-7: Compare and Contrast

Hard Bop, Modal Jazz, Free Jazz

The Progressive Liberation Narrative

Core Concept: Each period represents jazz freeing itself from increasingly fundamental constraints while maintaining core improvisational identity.

BEBOP (baseline): Complex rapid chord changes, virtuosic lines, intellectual art music, small group format, intense frenetic energy, vertical improvisation (outlining chords).

HARD BOP (Week 5): *What it freed:* Jazz from pure intellectualism and cool jazz's "whitening." *What it kept:* Complex harmony, virtuosity, chord changes, forms. *What it added:* Soul, gospel, blues feeling, groove, accessibility, Black cultural roots.

MODAL JAZZ (Week 6): *What it freed:* Jazz from "chasing changes" (rapid chord progressions). *What it kept:* Structure (modes), steady pulse, beauty, sophistication. *What it added:* Spacious contemplation, spiritual seeking, horizontal melodic development, static harmony.

FREE JAZZ (Week 7): *What it freed:* Jazz from ALL predetermined structures (harmony, form, meter). *What it kept:* Improvisation, intensity, expression, interaction. *What it added:* Complete freedom, extended techniques, confrontational art, raw emotional truth.

Key Relationships Between Periods

Hard Bop → Modal Jazz

The Simplification Move: Modal jazz simplified hard bop's complex chord progressions. Musicians like Miles and Coltrane tired of "chasing changes" and sought melodic freedom through static harmony. Both maintain sophistication but modal replaces harmonic density with spacious exploration.

Examples:

- Miles: "Oleo" (1956, hard bop with rhythm changes) → "So What" (1959, just 2 modes)
- Coltrane: "Giant Steps" (1959, ultimate bebop harmony) → "My Favorite Things" (1960, simple modal vamp)

Modal Jazz → Free Jazz

The Liberation Move: Free jazz abandoned modal jazz's remaining structures. Modal still had modes (scales), steady pulse, and formal beauty. Free jazz removed even these constraints for complete structural freedom and raw emotional expression.

Examples:

- Coltrane: "Acknowledgment" (1964, modal motif with pulse) → "Expression" (1967, no harmony/form/meter)
- Andrew Hill: "Refuge" (1964, modal but pushing toward chaos with Dolphy)

Hard Bop → Free Jazz (Skipping Modal)

The Soul Connection: Both emphasize feeling over pure intellectualism. Hard bop adds gospel/soul to bebop; free jazz adds raw spiritual catharsis. Both connect to Black cultural identity and Civil Rights context. Hard bop made jazz communal/danceable; free jazz made it confrontational protest.

Example: Mingus bridges both - "Better Git It in Your Soul" (1959, gospel-influenced hard bop with "organized chaos" foreshadowing free jazz's collective improvisation).

Relationship to Bebop: Side-by-Side

Element	Hard Bop	Modal Jazz	Free Jazz
Harmony	Maintains complex changes but adds groove	Static modes replace rapid changes	NO predetermined harmony, atonal
Rhythm	Strong walking bass, driving groove, danceable	Spacious pulse, ostinatos, floating feel	Free time, no steady pulse
Form	Standard forms (blues, AABA, contrafacts)	Standard forms with modal sections	NO fixed forms, complete freedom
Melody	Bebop vocabulary + soul inflection	Horizontal lines, spacious development	Extended techniques, extreme sounds
Energy	Accessible intensity, groove-oriented	Contemplative, meditative, spiritual	Confrontational, chaotic, raw
Cultural Context	Reclaim Black roots (gospel/blues)	Eastern philosophy, spiritual seeking	Civil Rights protest, complete liberation
Bebop Relationship	MODIFICATION - keeps complexity, adds accessibility	SIMPLIFICATION - removes harmonic density	REJECTION - abandons all bebop rules

Musical Characteristics Compared

Instrumentation

- **Hard Bop:** Standard bebop instrumentation (trumpet, tenor/alto, piano, bass, drums) but emphasizes interactive drumming (Blakey's press rolls) and walking bass groove
- **Modal Jazz:** Adds soprano sax (Coltrane), emphasizes non-walking melodic bass (Evans), quartal piano voicings (Tyner), incorporates bossa nova guitar (Getz)
- **Free Jazz:** Expands to bass clarinet (Dolphy), plastic saxophone (Coleman), removes piano to avoid harmony (Coleman, Ayler trios), extreme extended techniques on all instruments

Improvisation Approach

- **Hard Bop:** Bebop vocabulary with soul inflections, call-and-response with rhythm section, balances virtuosity with groove, audience participation (Adderley)

- **Modal Jazz:** Horizontal melodic development over static harmony, freed from "chasing changes," conversational intimacy (Evans), extended explorations over vamps (Coltrane 10+ minute solos)
- **Free Jazz:** Follows emotional arc not chords, collective improvisation with no hierarchy, extended techniques (multiphonics, overblowing, screaming), melody/harmony/rhythm equal (harmolodics)

Tempo and Feel

- **Hard Bop:** Medium tempo grooves dominate, emphasizes beats 1 & 3 (march feel) or strong 2 & 4 (swing), triplet feels (Mingus), shift between swing and straight eights (Adderley)
- **Modal Jazz:** Relaxed spacious pulse, odd meters accessible (5/4 in "Take Five"), 3/4 waltz time (Coltrane), floating ambiguous rhythm (Hancock), soft bossa nova grooves (Getz)
- **Free Jazz:** Free time (no steady pulse), variable tempo within pieces, dirge-like slow (Coleman "Lonely Woman"), or chaotic intense without meter (late Coltrane)

Harmony

- **Hard Bop:** Maintains bebop's ii-V progressions and rhythm changes but simplifies slightly for groove, 12-bar blues emphasis, gospel progressions, Latin/Caribbean vamps (Silver, Rollins)
- **Modal Jazz:** One or two modes for entire pieces, Dorian mode most common, quartal harmony (4ths not 3rds), suspended chords creating ambiguity, pedal points and ostinatos, eliminates functional progressions
- **Free Jazz:** Completely atonal (no tonal center), no predetermined chord structures, tone clusters (Taylor), avoids piano to prevent harmonic constraints, improvisation creates harmony in moment

Texture and Density

- **Hard Bop:** Dense polyphonic horn arrangements (Mingus), big sound from small groups, soloist-rhythm section interaction, powerful driving rhythm section creates full texture
- **Modal Jazz:** Sparse spacious texture, conversational interaction between equal voices (Evans trio), chamber music intimacy, open airy sound, space between notes valued
- **Free Jazz:** Extreme density through collective improvisation or sparse trio format, all musicians improvising simultaneously without hierarchy, chaotic layered textures or stark minimal accompaniment

Key Artists and Their Journeys

Miles Davis: Cool Jazz → Hard Bop → Modal Jazz

- "Boplicity" (1949): Cool jazz reaction against bebop - restrained, orchestral, gentle
- "Oleo" (1956): Hard bop with bebop changes but cool restraint
- "So What" (1959): Modal revolution - 2 modes, spacious, contemplative
- "Riot" (1967): Late modal with aggressive edge, rhythmic intensity

Arc: From bebop's intensity → cool restraint → hard bop balance → modal simplification → increasing intensity

John Coltrane: Hard Bop → Modal Jazz → Free Jazz

- "Giant Steps" (1959): Ultimate bebop harmony endpoint - Coltrane changes, sheets of sound
- "My Favorite Things" (1960): Modal simplicity - E minor/major vamp, soprano sax, spiritual exploration

- "Acknowledgment" (1964): Modal spiritual suite - simple motif, devotional
- "Expression" (1967): Completely free - no harmony/form/meter, multiphonics, apocalyptic

Arc: Bebop complexity → modal simplification → spiritual seeking → complete freedom (died age 40, 1967)

Other Key Figures

- **Art Blakey:** Hard bop drummer - emphasized groove and accessibility, signature press rolls, gospel feel
- **Horace Silver:** Soul jazz - funky gospel-influenced piano, Cape Verdean influences, vamp structures
- **Bill Evans:** Modal piano - impressionistic (Ravel/Debussy), conversational trio, eliminated walking bass
- **Ornette Coleman:** Free jazz pioneer - plastic alto, no piano, harmolodics theory, "Shape of Jazz to Come"
- **Cecil Taylor:** Free jazz piano - tone clusters, atonal, classical training destroys bebop conventions

Historical and Cultural Context

Mid-1950s: Hard Bop Emerges

Reacting against: Cool jazz's "whitening" of bebop, intellectualism becoming inaccessible

Reclaiming: Black cultural roots through gospel, blues, soul, church music

Context: Early Civil Rights movement, competition with rock and roll, making jazz danceable

Geography: East Coast (NYC) sound vs West Coast cool jazz

Readings: Szweid calls it "subconsciously racial" - mid-50s Black urban music from folk/church/blues

Late 1950s: Modal Jazz Revolution

Reacting against: Complexity of chord-chasing, density of hard bop

Seeking: Melodic freedom, space, contemplation, spirituality

Context: 1959 "multiple revolutions" year - Kind of Blue, Giant Steps, Time Out

Influences: Eastern philosophy, meditation, impressionist classical music (Ravel/Debussy)

Readings: Berliner's "Very Structured Thing" - improvisation as language with grammar

Early 1960s: Free Jazz Emerges

Reacting against: ALL remaining structural constraints, even modal structures

Seeking: Complete freedom, raw emotional truth, confrontational protest art

Context: Civil Rights era intensifies - musical freedom = social/political freedom

Philosophy: Emotion over beauty, truth over pleasure, catharsis over intellectualism

Reception: Called "anti-jazz" by critics (DownBeat on Dolphy), lost mainstream audiences

Key Terms Across Periods

Hard Bop Terms

Soul jazz, sheets of sound, walking bass, press roll, organized chaos, contrafact, gospel call-and-response, calypso rhythm, Latin beat, vamp

Modal Jazz Terms

Mode, Dorian mode, vamp, ostinato, pedal point, quartal harmony, suspended chords, bossa nova, impressionistic, chamber music texture, horizontal improvisation

Free Jazz Terms

Atonality, collective improvisation, harmolodics, extended techniques, altissimo register, free time, plastic saxophone, tone clusters, multiphonics, fire music, overblowing

Test Preparation: Key Contrasts

If asked to compare Hard Bop and Modal Jazz:

Both move away from bebop but in different directions. Hard bop KEEPS bebop's complex harmony but ADDS soul/groove/accessibility. Modal jazz REMOVES bebop's harmonic complexity for static modes. Hard bop emphasizes feeling through groove; modal emphasizes space through simplification. Hard bop reclaims Black cultural roots; modal seeks Eastern spiritual philosophy. Example: Compare Coltrane's "Giant Steps" (hard bop's ultimate harmony) to "My Favorite Things" (modal simplicity).

If asked to compare Modal Jazz and Free Jazz:

Modal jazz freed improvisers from chord changes but kept structural constraints (modes, pulse, beauty). Free jazz removed ALL structures including modes. Modal is contemplative and spacious; free is confrontational and chaotic. Modal maintains steady pulse; free uses free time. Modal seeks beauty through simplicity; free seeks truth regardless of beauty. Example: Compare Coltrane's "Acknowledgment" (modal motif with pulse) to "Expression" (complete structural freedom).

If asked to compare Hard Bop and Free Jazz:

Hard bop maintains bebop's structural sophistication while adding accessibility; free jazz completely rejects bebop's structures. BUT both emphasize feeling over pure intellectualism and connect to Black cultural identity. Hard bop makes jazz communal through gospel/soul; free jazz makes it confrontational through raw expression. Both relate to Civil Rights context but differently - hard bop reclaims roots, free jazz demands liberation. Example: Compare Mingus's "organized chaos" (structured collective improvisation) to Coleman's complete harmonic freedom.

If asked how all three relate to bebop:

Hard bop MODIFIES bebop (keeps complexity, adds soul). Modal jazz SIMPLIFIES bebop (removes harmonic density). Free jazz REJECTS bebop (abandons all rules). This represents progressive liberation: first from intellectualism → then from harmonic constraints → finally from all structural constraints. All three maintain improvisation as core but increasingly free themselves from bebop's foundational principles.

Practice Comparative Analysis

Question: "How do 'Giant Steps,' 'So What,' and 'Lonely Woman' represent the evolution from bebop through hard bop, modal, and free jazz?"

Answer Framework: "Giant Steps" (1959) represents hard bop's pinnacle of bebop harmony through Coltrane changes that divide the octave into thirds with rapid ii-V progressions, maintaining bebop's chord-based improvisation at ultimate complexity. "So What" (1959, same year!) represents modal jazz's revolutionary departure through static harmony using only two Dorian modes, freeing improvisers from "chasing changes" for horizontal melodic development over spacious contemplative textures. "Lonely Woman" (1959, same year!) represents free jazz's complete harmonic abandonment, with no predetermined chord changes and improvisation following emotional arc rather than structure, recorded without piano to avoid constraints. These three 1959 recordings show the simultaneous "multiple revolutions" where jazz fragmented into different approaches to freedom from bebop's complexity.